What are grain prices going to do?

The secret no one tells you about predicting price



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“If a man can write a better book, preach a better sermon or make a better mouse trap than his neighbors, though he builds his house in the woods, the world will make a beaten path to his door” - Ralph Waldo Emerson

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First load of Harvest 2026

This past weekend was the first of harvest for us in Southeastern Illinois. It’s always a battle to get going and the weather was a bit too warm for my liking but a successful one all in all.

As my father and I were working on the combine and corn head Saturday morning there were four farmers who stopped to chat and ask us how things were going. All four of them asked us what grain prices were going to do in the next few months. One of them asked us, 'If they go down do you think they'll be back up by November?'

My father and I are both commodity brokers. He has spent his career working with producers whereas up until recently I was on the elevator side. With this comes almost constant inquiries as to where we see the price of grains going and when. He's dealt with it a lot longer than me.

Sometimes you dance around and try to give a full perspective on market factors, other times you just bite the bullet and give a prediction. Never do you really enjoy the back and forth. The predictions feel shallow and it's hard to explain price in a few minutes without losing the person completely. Lately I've been giving the shortest and shallowest prediction I can that conforms to my price bias just hoping and praying that the person doesn't make true financial decisions on what I said while covered in grease trying to tighten a chain on a worn-out corn head.

It's a lose-lose situation. Either I'm completely wrong, and my credentials for the role of local idiot continue to climb. Or I'm correct enough to be wrong about when the move ends (i.e. I say it'll rally in the spring, and it does but after the farmer sells it rallies all the way into planting). In both cases the prediction I gave wasn't worth the breath it took to say it or the energy your ears spent listening to it.

A prediction doesn't know your bottom line. It doesn't know your logistics needs. It doesn't know when you prefer to ship corn and when you prefer to mow ditches. A prediction assumes that you are in the same boat as everyone else and your goal is to sell the most bushels at the highest possible price. You're not in that boat. I repeat: you are not in that boat. You're running your own race with your own unique opportunities to capitalize on and problems to solve.

‘Mitch what the hell do you mean? Why would I want to sell anything else but the high?’

Okay, what if the high comes on the day your shed catches on fire? Are you going to stop what you’re doing and load corn while you watch it burn? No. You’re money ahead to put out the fire. The high could also come during the exact time you can’t find a trucker. Do you pay the guy hauling for your neighbor double so he hauls for you? No. Your freight rate would negate the gain to sell the high. This is not to mention you have no clue WHEN the high is in the first place. Neither do I. Neither does anyone else.

So why do people on the internet and in magazines spend so much time talking about what price might do and when?

1. 1. It gets your attention
2. 2. It makes everyone feel good
3. 3. It drives profit

Why does the local seed company pay for an analyst to come to their field day and put on a presentation? See 1-3 above.

Why is that guy dressed in a flashy suit with the grain prices rolling on a ribbon on the bottom of the screen? See 1-3 above.

Why do brokers on X talk above price movement daily? See 1-3 above.

This isn't 'everyone's trying to sell you something.' They are. But there's no sinister intent. Most of those people are great professionals and genuinely want to see you succeed. Most of the time they make great points that can legitimately help you make decisions. What I’m telling you is that the analysis, predictions and charts are all just tools to be used to make the best decision you can for your operation.

Trying to guess where price goes is how people lose their lunch, lose sleep at night and get eaten alive by stress. Good business is good business.

At its core that is what I hope to do. What are your needs today? How can we make the market work for you instead of playing catch up? I would much rather explore those opportunities than give you my price bias. The only reason I ever publish a price bias is to start a conversation.

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